

Safe System of Work

Loading and Unloading of Plant & Machinery

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Record of Amendments

Next Review Due Date:	31.08.2026
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Overview

The following information provides guidance on the company's Safe System of Work for works that involve the loading and unloading of Plant and Machinery onto a Low-Loader.

The loading and unloading of Plant & Machinery can be dangerous. The machinery or load can seriously hurt people. A lot of vehicles overturn each year, sometimes causing fatal accidents.

All employees have a responsibility for their safety and the safety of others by adhering to these codes of practice.

The Operator must always refer to any applicable task Risk Assessment and Method Statements prior to starting works.

Hazards Identified

- Adverse weather
- Crushing
- Machine Rollover
- Cuts and abrasions
- Vehicle movements
- Falls from height.
- Manual handling
- Slips & Trips.
- Lone Working

Personal Protective Equipment (PPE) Requirements



Transporting mobile plant must be risk assessed and undertaken safely as with the movement of any loads. Prior to loading and offloading mobile plant, a Loading/Unloading Checklist (FG-SLCL-01) is to be completed by the Driver responsible for the task. The Driver must load the vehicle safely onto the transport vehicle and ensure the correct stowage of any attachments and ancillaries.

General Safety Requirements

In general, when loading and offloading vehicles, you must:

- Use only suitably competent operators for any transport vehicle or lifting plant used
- Have supervision in controlling the task
- Never overload a vehicle or the lifting plant
- Evenly distribute load
- The vehicle being loaded/offloaded must be parked in a fundamentally safe manner that prevents any inadvertent runaway, with wheels chocked if necessary
- Where the mobile equipment is wider than the vehicle deck, a widening low loaders or extensions should be used for maximum support. At least 75% of the normal contact area of equipment, tyres or tracks should be supported. Any unsupported tyre or track should not project more than 150 mm beyond the vehicle deck or extension.
- Use an agreed method of loading / unloading (i.e. do not push or pull the item from the transport vehicle so the load goes into free fall)
- Ensure drivers and operators are responsible for securing their load before moving
- Ensure covers are used on Tipper trucks to control Dust and Spills
- Ensure that communication between those involved in the load / unload is agreed and understood
- No one is to be in the radius of the plant used to load or unload, stand in a location where the operator can clearly see you
- Do not stand near side or on the far side of the truck while being unloaded.
- Drivers must observe and adhere to the direction of any Site Traffic Management Plan
- Not project loads beyond the sides or back of the transporting vehicle – where some degree of overhang is unavoidable, ensure that:
 - Overhang is visibly marked by approved signage i.e. red flags, marker boards.
 - Use additional lighting.
 - Necessary authorities are formally notified.
 - There is a warning vehicle in attendance.

When offloading, ropes & fixes must be removed with caution as loads may move when unsecured

The Driver must meet the following requirements.

Lone Working

If a Driver identifies that the loading/unloading site is unmanned on arrival, they must:

- Contact the office immediately to inform that they will be Lone Working whilst undertaking the task.
- Provide an estimation of how long the task will take.
- Once the task is complete, the driver will contact the office again to inform them and that they are leaving site.
- If the driver has not contacted the office at the end of the estimated completion time, the office will contact the Driver for an update.
- If contact can not be made with the Driver, the Lone Worker Emergency Procedure will be initiated.

Use of Ramps

- Ramps are to be secure and long enough to keep the ramp at a low angle. (The ramps are an integral part of the vehicle / trailer. If the ramps are removable they must be supplied by a manufacturer which are suitable for the Vehicle or trailer & the load) designed, load rated, approved and fit for purpose.
- Always check the ramps prior to use for any damage
- Always use the securing components (such as pins and R-clips) that are supplied or recommended by the ramp manufacturer
- Follow the manufacturer's instructions for correctly installing and using the recognised securing systems
- Ensure that the ramps are load rated and suitable for the item being loaded or unloaded (including any additional attachments)

Prepare for Loading and Offloading

Before driving the mobile plant on or off the vehicle, the driver/mobile plant operator must:

- Confirm with site management that the approved location for loading/offloading area is sufficient to accommodate the movement of the plant without causing hazards
- The transporter is on firm, level ground and correctly positioned with its brakes on & with no side slope
- Any ramps are secured and long enough to keep the ramp angle low
- The mobile plant transmission, clutches, brakes, etc. are working correctly – where the plant is inoperable, the transporter must use a loading winch for the task
- Prior to loading or off-loading the operator is to consider the method on how the activity will take place, this needs to be undertaken considering: the Environment, type of plant, access, fall protection, the OEM recommendations, SWMS/Risk Assessment, the vehicle & ramp specifications

Load and Offload Plant Safely

When loading or offloading, the driver/plant operator must ensure:

- The mobile plant is lined up with the ramps so that no steering of the plant is needed in the process
- Use fitted seatbelts
- Loading or offloading is carried out at the slowest possible speed, particularly at any point of balance
- Any necessary movement of the mobile plant whilst on the transporter (e.g. to centre it), is carefully executed

When a mobile plant is loaded onto a low-loader and positioned to the satisfaction of the driver, every precaution must be taken to ensure that the vehicle cannot change its position during transit. The mobile plant operator and/or the transport Driver must ensure that the mobile plant:

- Has the brakes engaged
- Is securely lashed
- Has any loose items (e.g. spare buckets) securely lashed
- Has slewing arms or other movable parts secure and cannot become dislodged during transport
- (Wheels are chocked)

See SSoW14 – Securing Plant & Machinery in Transit

When mobile plant is unloaded from the low-loader, the driver must position and park the machine safely and in a position as not to obstruct other site users and vehicles.